

Introduction

Windows 8 can be a confusing release for consumers even before they have used it at all. Should you hate it, or should you like it? “Love it to bits” and “hate with a passion” are both valid opinions, but there seems to be no conclusion for Windows 8. Hopefully this FastTrack will give you some much-needed closure.

Windows 8 took some time to develop its reputation. Microsoft announced change after change for their upcoming OS, and people were mostly fine, happy even. Even the confirmation that Explorer would use the ribbon only slightly dampened the joy.

But one cold, damp morning Microsoft finally announced to a media rife with trepidation, that the Start Menu had passed away. A collective “oh you didn’t” resounded through the masses and things just got real. Microsoft had gone too far, the line must be drawn here, people said, this far and no further.

Windows 8 was then heavily criticised by Valve co-founder Gabe Newell. He really disliked the idea of Microsoft having monopoly of the Windows ecosystem. After all Valve runs its own very successful app store for Windows, called Steam, which has branched out to selling general-purpose software in addition to games. If Windows is locked down now, Steam will have no future.

There is a little truth in nearly every criticism of Windows 8 whether positive or negative. Yes, Microsoft has started pushing an inbuilt store, not as an option, but as the only way to purchase the new Modern UI applications. Yes, the Windows 8 UI is clunky and disjointed at places, but not because the new UI is bad, but because the marriage between the classic and Modern UIs is unstable to say the least. Depending on how you look at it, either the Classic UI seems tacked on, or the new UI does.